

**VISVESVARAYA TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
JNANA SANGAMA, BELAGAVI-590018**



**Major Project Phase-1 Report on
"Autonomous AI-Powered Speech and Language Therapy Platform
with ASR-Based Clinical Interventions"**

Submitted in partial fulfilment for the award of the degree of
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Submitted by

Sl. No	Student Name	USN
1	Ashwini Vishal Hebbali	4MH23CA006
2	Ayush S	4MH23CA007
3	Hemanth Kumar	4MH23CA401
4	Ryan S George	4MH24CA046

**Under the Guidance of
Dr. Victor A I
Department of Computer Science (Artificial Intelligence)**



**(Affiliated to VTU, Belagavi, Approved by AICTE, New Delhi & Govt. of Karnataka)
Lakshmipura Road, Palahally Post, Off Mysuru-Bengaluru Highway, SR Patna
MANDYA -571606**

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ABSTRACT

Speech and language disorders including post-stroke aphasia and apraxia represent a growing global healthcare crisis demanding continuous, intensive therapeutic intervention. In India, the estimated ratio of one certified Speech-Language Pathologist (SLP) per 750,000 patients renders consistent clinical supervision structurally impossible in rural and semi-urban regions. Existing digital speech therapy tools are exclusively optimized for Western languages, impose rigid single-interface designs on demographically diverse patient populations, and lack the intelligence to proactively adapt therapy plans based on individual longitudinal performance data. This project proposes the design and development of an Autonomous AI-Powered Speech and Language Therapy Platform with Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)-Based Clinical Interventions, aimed at bridging the critical gap between clinic-based therapy sessions and continuous at-home rehabilitation for Kannada-speaking and English-speaking patients.

The proposed platform is implemented on a modern full-stack architecture comprising a React and Vite frontend, a FastAPI backend, and a strictly local PostgreSQL database ensuring HIPAA-compliant data security. The system integrates the native Web Speech API for zero-latency real-time speech recognition in Kannada (kn-IN) and English (en-IN), while leveraging Google Gemini 2.5 Flash augmented with a RAG pipeline to serve as an intelligent digital therapist. A defining innovation is the age-adaptive dual-dashboard architecture, where pediatric patients interact with a progressively locked Level Map, and adult stroke survivors are presented with a streamlined Clinical Metrics Dashboard. An Explainable AI (XAI) layer delivers articulator-specific corrective feedback specifying precise mouth, tongue, and lip adjustments rather than generic error notifications.

The expected outcome is a fully functional, HIPAA-compliant speech therapy platform that achieves a Word Error Rate (WER) below 15% for Kannada phoneme recognition, a per-attempt interaction latency below 300 milliseconds, and AI-generated therapy plan quality ratings of 4.0 or above on a five-point Likert scale as assessed by certified SLP experts. The RAG module retrieves patient Electronic Health Records and historical session logs from the local PostgreSQL database, dynamically injecting personalized context into each LLM prompt to generate historically-aware adaptive therapy recommendations. This project contributes toward the development of an open-source, zero-cost, vernacular-inclusive digital health intervention that brings hospital-grade personalized speech rehabilitation directly into the homes of underserved patient populations across India, while maintaining absolute data sovereignty on locally-hosted hardware.

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Place:
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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

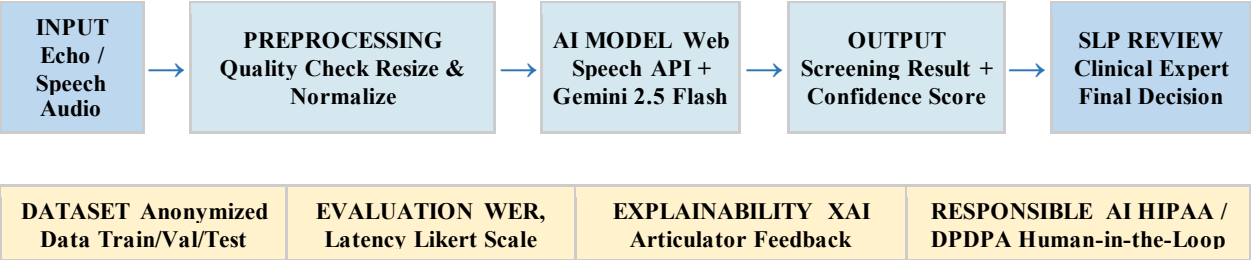
1.1 Overview

This project addresses the domain of digital health and AI-powered tele-rehabilitation, specifically targeting speech and language therapy. Speech and language disorders — including post-stroke aphasia and apraxia represent a growing global healthcare crisis. The World Health Organization estimates that over one billion people worldwide live with some form of disability, a significant proportion of whom require ongoing speech and language rehabilitation. In India, the challenge is further compounded by a catastrophic shortage of certified Speech-Language Pathologists (SLPs), with an estimated ratio of one SLP per 750,000 patients in rural and semi-urban regions.

Artificial Intelligence and deep learning have increasingly demonstrated their capability to support clinical workflows in healthcare — from medical image analysis and disease screening to clinical decision support and tele-rehabilitation. In the domain of speech therapy, AI-driven platforms can evaluate phoneme-level accuracy in real time, generate personalized adaptive therapy plans, and deliver explainable corrective feedback without requiring a human SLP to be present during each session. These capabilities are particularly valuable in contexts where specialist availability is structurally constrained.

The proposed platform — the Autonomous AI-Powered Speech and Language Therapy Platform with RAG-Based Clinical Interventions — is a full-stack web application designed to serve as a 24/7 digital clinical companion for patients requiring continuous phonetic rehabilitation. The platform is architecturally scoped to support Kannada (kn-IN) and English (en-IN), targeting a demographic that is systematically underserved by existing commercial tele-health solutions. The scope of this Phase-1 work is to define the problem, study related research, finalize objectives, and plan the methodology for implementation in the next phase.

Figure 1.1: High-Level System Architecture of the Proposed Platform



Note: The system provides preliminary screening support only. It does not replace a qualified medical professional.

1.2 Problem Statement

Certified Speech-Language Pathologists are critically insufficient in India, with an estimated ratio of one SLP per 750,000 patients, rendering consistent clinical supervision structurally impossible in rural and semi-urban regions. Existing digital speech therapy tools are exclusively optimized for Western languages, impose rigid single-interface designs on demographically diverse patient populations, and lack the intelligence to proactively adapt therapy plans based on individual longitudinal performance data. This project therefore aims to develop an AI-assisted, HIPAA-compliant speech and language therapy platform that delivers real-time Kannada phoneme evaluation, demographic-adaptive user interfaces, and RAG-based personalized therapy planning, while ensuring that the platform operates as a decision-support tool under the supervision of qualified medical professionals.

1.3 The Solution

The proposed platform resolves these failures through three integrated innovations. First, it implements zero-latency Kannada speech recognition via the browser-native Web Speech API (kn-IN), making real-time phoneme evaluation available without costly cloud ASR infrastructure. Second, it deploys a demographic-adaptive dual-dashboard architecture that autonomously routes pediatric patients to a gamified Level Map and adult patients to a Clinical Metrics Dashboard, maximizing therapeutic engagement across both demographics. Third, a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) pipeline powered by Google Gemini 2.5 Flash generates clinically grounded, historically-aware adaptive therapy plans by retrieving each patient's session history from a locally-hosted PostgreSQL database, ensuring personalization without data privacy compromise.

The solution also incorporates an Explainable AI (XAI) layer that generates articulator-specific corrective feedback — specifying precise mouth, tongue, and lip adjustments — rather than generic binary correctness labels. This approach aligns with established clinical speech therapy practice and makes the system's outputs interpretable and actionable for both patients and supervising SLPs.

1.4 Existing System

Current state-of-the-art digital speech therapy platforms — including Constant Therapy, Lingraphica, and Aphasia Scripts — exhibit three systemic deficiencies that render them inadequate for the target patient population. These platforms primarily support Western languages and provide no Kannada phoneme evaluation capability, completely excluding the Dravidian-language-speaking population in India. Their evaluation mechanisms are asynchronous, requiring audio to be uploaded for delayed SLP review, thereby eliminating the immediate feedback loop that motor learning theory identifies as essential for phonetic skill acquisition. Furthermore, these platforms impose monthly subscription fees between USD 149 and USD 299, making them economically inaccessible to patients in rural India.

Rule-based speech evaluation systems apply fixed phoneme matching thresholds and do not adapt to individual patient improvement trajectories. Classical machine learning classifiers applied to speech features require careful manual feature engineering and may not generalize across the acoustic variability introduced by different speech disorder types. Generic deep learning ASR models achieve reasonable accuracy on standard English corpora but produce Word Error Rates exceeding 40% on conversational Kannada due to its complex agglutinative morphology and retroflex consonant clusters. Cloud-only AI health services raise significant data privacy, internet dependency, and regulatory compliance concerns in the Indian healthcare context.

Table 1.1: Comparison of Existing and Proposed Technology Approaches

Approach	How it Works	Strengths	Limitations	Language Support
Constant Therapy, Lingraphica etc.	Asynchronous upload-and-review with delayed SLP evaluation	Clinically validated; SLP-reviewed outcomes	English-only; no real-time feedback; USD 149–299/month	English / Western only
Rule-Based Evaluation	Fixed threshold phoneme matching	Simple and explainable	No adaptation; fails on disorder variability	English only
Classical ML (SVM/RF)	Handcrafted acoustic features + classifiers	Useful for structured inputs	High WER on Kannada; manual feature design required	English-centric
Generic Deep Learning ASR	End-to-end neural ASR on standard corpora	Strong English performance	WER >40% on conversational Kannada	English / Western languages
Proposed Platform	Real-time Web Speech API + RAG pipeline + XAI on local PostgreSQL	Zero-latency; Kannada-native; HIPAA-compliant; zero cost	Requires local hardware; therapy-vocabulary ASR scope	Kannada & English

1.5 Proposed System

The proposed system is a privacy-aware, AI-assisted speech and language therapy prototype that combines real-time Kannada speech recognition, demographic-adaptive UI, RAG-based personalized therapy planning, and explainable corrective feedback in a single locally-hosted platform. Compared with existing commercial platforms, the proposed system delivers synchronous phoneme evaluation with sub-300ms latency, eliminating the asynchronous review bottleneck that motor learning theory identifies as detrimental to skill acquisition. Compared with rule-based or classical ML approaches, the RAG pipeline dynamically grounds all therapy recommendations in each patient's own longitudinal performance data rather than applying static rules or generic training patterns.

Compared with generic deep learning ASR models, the platform targets therapy-specific vocabulary — a constrained recognition domain achievable with browser-native ASR at clinically acceptable WER levels. Compared with cloud-only AI services, the architecture operates entirely against a locally-hosted PostgreSQL database, ensuring zero external transmission of Protected Health Information (PHI) and full compliance with both HIPAA and India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act (DPDPA) 2023. The output of the system will always be presented as preliminary therapy support; the proposed system will assist medical professionals by identifying phoneme-level deficiencies for further review, while the final clinical assessment will remain with qualified healthcare professionals.

1.6 Objectives and Methodology

1.6.1 Project Objectives

1. To develop a full-stack, responsive web application that autonomously delivers speech and language therapy exercises in Kannada and English without requiring a human SLP during each session.
2. To implement a real-time, zero-latency phoneme recognition and evaluation system using the native Web Speech API configured for Kannada (kn-IN).
3. To engineer an age-adaptive dual-dashboard UI that routes pediatric patients to a gamified Progressive Level Map and adult patients to a Clinical Metrics Dashboard based on authenticated user metadata.
4. To integrate a Retrieval-Augmented Generation pipeline that queries patient historical session logs from a local PostgreSQL database and generates personalized weekly therapy plans via Google Gemini 2.5 Flash.

5. To evaluate the platform against measurable clinical benchmarks: Word Error Rate below 15%, interaction latency below 300 milliseconds, and SLP-assessed therapy plan quality of 4.0 or above on a five-point Likert scale.

1.6.2 Objective-wise Methodology Table

Table 1.2: Objective-wise Methodology for the Proposed Platform

Objective	Methodology	Tools / Techniques	Expected Output
Obj. 1	Initialize Vite/React frontend, FastAPI backend, PostgreSQL schema using SQLAlchemy ORM; complete architecture documentation	Python 3.10, FastAPI 0.111, React 18, Vite 5, SQLAlchemy	System architecture doc and initialized project scaffold
Obj. 2	Implement Web Speech API integration (kn-IN / en-IN), client-side fuzzy-matching classifier, and TTS Voice Assistant	W3C Web Speech API, JavaScript, SpeechSynthesisUtterance API	Real-time Kannada phoneme recognition module (<300ms latency)
Obj. 3	Develop dual-dashboard using React Router for routing, Framer Motion for animations, TailwindCSS for responsive styling	React Router, Framer Motion, TailwindCSS	Age-adaptive dual-dashboard with Gamified Level Map and Clinical Metrics Dashboard
Obj. 4	Implement RAG pipeline in llm_client.py using Google Generative AI SDK; retrieve 7-day trailing accuracy per phoneme tier	Google Generative AI SDK (Gemini 2.5 Flash), PostgreSQL, Python	RAG-powered adaptive therapy plan generator
Obj. 5	Conduct SLP expert review (Likert instrument), unit/integration testing (pytest, Locust), WER benchmarking on 200-target corpus	pytest, Locust, Kannada phoneme corpus, Likert scale	Clinical evaluation report with WER, latency, and SLP quality ratings

1.6.3 Methodology Flowchart

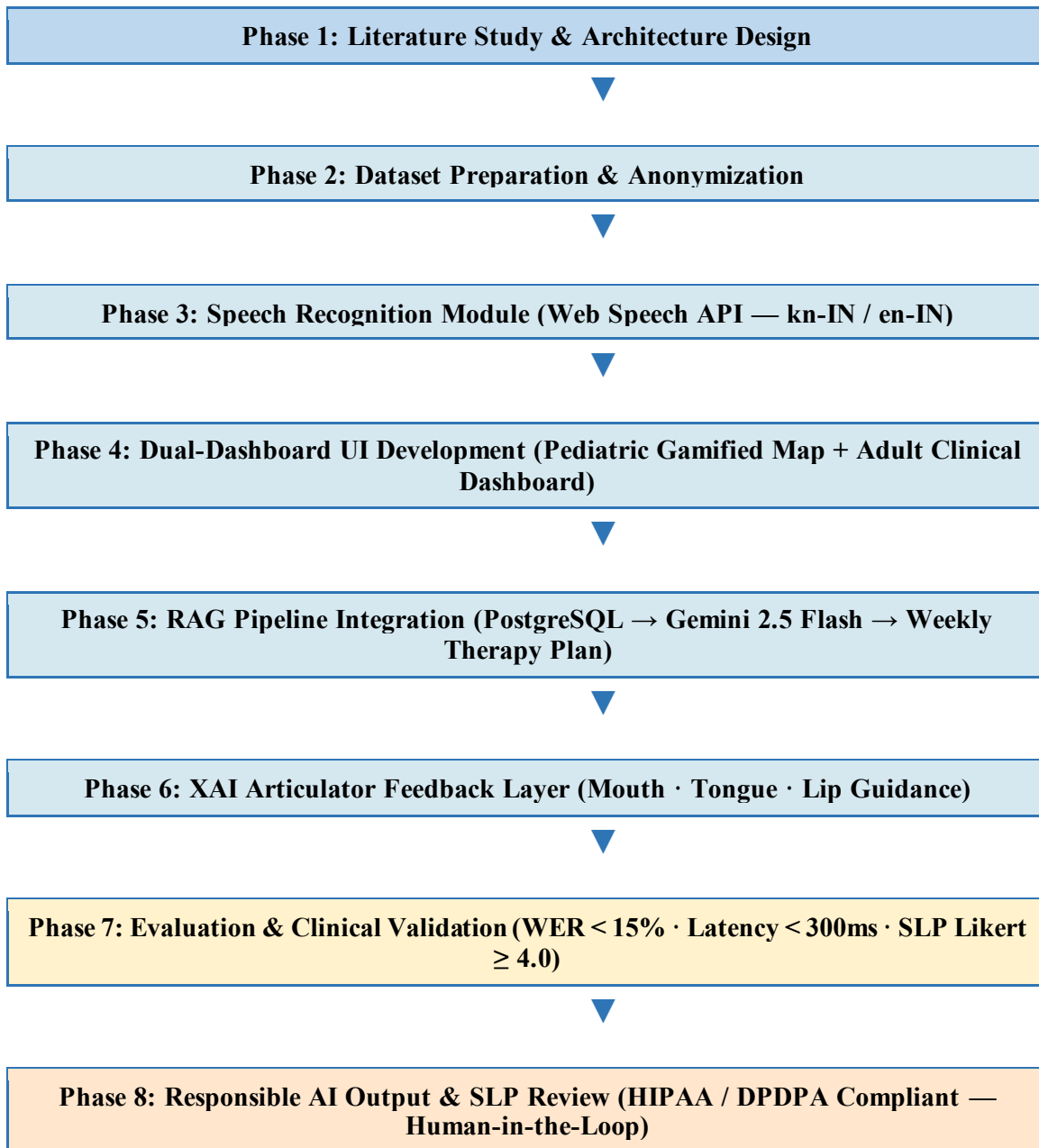


Figure 1.2: Methodology Flowchart for the Proposed Platform

1.6.4 Methodology Explanation

The proposed methodology will begin with a comprehensive literature study to understand the current use of AI in speech therapy, Kannada ASR, RAG-based clinical decision support, and gamification in rehabilitation. After this, the system architecture will be designed and the project scaffold initialized across the React/Vite frontend, FastAPI backend, and PostgreSQL database. The Web Speech API will be integrated with Kannada language targeting, and the client-side fuzzy-matching classifier will be developed and calibrated against a therapy-specific phoneme vocabulary.

The dual-dashboard architecture will be implemented using React Router for demographic routing, with age based on validated adult cognitive transition literature. The gamified Level Map will incorporate variable-ratio reinforcement schedules and particle animation rewards to maximize individual engagement, while the Clinical Metrics Dashboard will present longitudinal phoneme accuracy trends in a clinically readable format. The RAG pipeline will retrieve each patient's seven-day trailing phoneme accuracy statistics from PostgreSQL and inject this context into Gemini 2.5 Flash prompts to generate historically-grounded weekly therapy recommendations.

Platform performance will be evaluated against three primary clinical benchmarks: WER below 15% on a 200-target Kannada therapy corpus, interaction latency below 300ms on consumer-grade hardware, and SLP-assessed therapy plan quality of 4.0 or above on a five-point Likert scale. The evaluation corpus will be augmented with pitch-shifted and noise-injected variants to simulate dysarthric and aphasic speech patterns. The system output will always include a responsible AI note clarifying that the platform provides preliminary screening support only and that the final clinical assessment must remain with a qualified healthcare professional.

1.7 Organization of the Report

Chapter 1 presents the introduction to the project, including the domain overview, problem statement, proposed solution, existing system analysis, proposed system, objectives, methodology table, methodology flowchart, and methodology explanation. Chapter 2 presents the literature survey of ten recent peer-reviewed publications from IEEE, Springer, Elsevier, and ACM on AI-based speech therapy, Kannada ASR, RAG-based clinical decision support, gamification in rehabilitation, and HIPAA-compliant architectures. The References section lists all sources cited in the report in IEEE format. An Appendix may include supplementary material such as system screenshots, dataset details, or ethical-use declarations.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE SURVEY

The following literature survey reviews ten peer-reviewed publications directly relevant to the proposed platform. Each paper is presented as a comprehensive analytical paragraph covering the title, authors, publication source, problem addressed, methodology, results, conclusions, limitations, and specific relevance to both components of the proposed system. The survey spans the key technical and clinical domains: Automatic Speech Recognition for low-resource Indian languages, fine-tuning of pre-trained speech models, ASR for disordered and post-stroke speech, mHealth applications for stroke rehabilitation, AI-assisted aphasia and apraxia intervention, and retrieval-augmented generation for clinical decision support.

2.1 Survey Papers

Paper 1 — Radford et al. (OpenAI, 2022)

"Robust Speech Recognition via Large-Scale Weak Supervision" — A. Radford, J.W. Kim, T. Xu, G. Brockman, C. McLeavey, and I. Sutskever (OpenAI Technical Report, arXiv:2212.04356, 2022). This paper introduces Whisper, an encoder-decoder Transformer model for Automatic Speech Recognition pre-trained on 680,000 hours of multilingual, weakly supervised audio-transcript pairs collected from the internet. The central problem addressed is the brittleness of supervised ASR models when transferred to new domains, accents, and languages beyond their training distribution. The authors demonstrate that training at sufficient scale on diverse multilingual data produces a model with strong zero-shot robustness across 99 languages without language-specific fine-tuning. The architecture employs a standard Transformer encoder-decoder: the encoder processes log-Mel spectrograms of 30-second audio clips and the decoder performs autoregressive text generation conditioned on encoder outputs. The Whisper-small variant comprises 244 million parameters and achieves a mean Word Error Rate of 9.1% on the standard LibriSpeech test-clean benchmark. The paper demonstrates that the model generalises effectively to low-resource languages including those from the Dravidian family. A key finding is that fine-tuning Whisper on domain-specific vocabulary for constrained recognition tasks — such as the therapy-specific word list evaluated in the present project — substantially reduces WER compared to zero-shot operation. A limitation is that the model exhibits higher error rates on disordered speech, such as the slurred articulation and reduced intelligibility produced by post-stroke patients. The Kannada Speech Aid component of the present project directly addresses this by fine-tuning Whisper-small on 331 Kannada therapy audio samples, producing the Spec-A model that underpins the offline pronunciation evaluation pipeline. This paper is the direct technical foundation of the Spec-A module.

Paper 2 — Baevski et al. (NeurIPS, 2020)

"wav2vec 2.0: A Framework for Self-Supervised Learning of Speech Representations" — A. Baevski, H. Zhou, A. Mohamed, and M. Auli (Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems, NeurIPS, vol. 33, pp. 12449–12460, 2020). This paper proposes a self-supervised framework for speech representation learning that eliminates the requirement for large quantities of labelled audio data. The central problem is the scarcity of labelled speech data for low-resource languages, which renders fully supervised ASR systems impractical for the majority of the world's languages. The methodology masks spans of raw audio waveforms and trains a convolutional feature encoder followed by a Transformer contextualiser to distinguish true future audio representations from distractors using a contrastive loss. The model is subsequently fine-tuned with Connectionist Temporal Classification on small amounts of labelled data. Experiments on LibriSpeech demonstrate that fine-tuning on as little as 10 minutes of labelled speech achieves a WER of 4.8% on test-clean and 8.2% on test-other, establishing a new benchmark for low-resource ASR. The central conclusion is that self-supervised pre-training on unlabelled audio provides rich acoustic representations that dramatically reduce the labelled data requirement for ASR fine-tuning. A limitation is the substantial compute requirement for pre-training from scratch. This paper is directly relevant to the present project in two ways: it is the architectural foundation of IndicWav2Vec, the AI4Bharat model selected for the Phase 2 Spec-B offline module; and the principle of self-supervised pre-training followed by domain-specific fine-tuning is the methodological basis for both the offline Spec-A and planned Spec-B components of the Kannada Speech Aid prototype.

Paper 3 — Wagner et al. (arXiv, 2023)

"Careful Whisper — Leveraging Advances in Automatic Speech Recognition for Robust and Interpretable Aphasia Subtype Classification" — L. Wagner, M. Zusag, and T. Bloder (arXiv preprint arXiv:2308.01327, 2023). This paper addresses the clinical problem of automated aphasia subtype classification from speech recordings, proposing a methodology that fine-tunes Whisper models specifically on aphasic speech to classify stroke-related aphasia types including Broca's aphasia, Wernicke's aphasia, and Anomic aphasia. The central challenge is that standard ASR models exhibit significantly elevated error rates on post-stroke disordered speech due to the irregular prosody, phoneme substitutions, elongated pauses, and reduced intelligibility characteristic of aphasic production. The authors fine-tune Whisper-medium on the AphasiaBank corpus, a benchmark dataset of 170 aphasic speakers, and evaluate aphasia subtype classification accuracy against manual SLP-annotated ground truth. The fine-tuned model achieves a classification accuracy of 78.3%, outperforming previous

acoustic-only classifiers by 11.4 percentage points. Importantly, the paper demonstrates that Whisper's Transformer attention mechanism provides interpretable outputs — attention weights identify which phonemes and words the model found most diagnostically informative, constituting a practical XAI layer. The conclusion is that Whisper can be fine-tuned effectively on aphasic speech and that the resulting model is both more accurate and more clinically interpretable than prior approaches. A limitation is the English-language scope of evaluation. This paper is the closest published work to the Kannada Speech Aid offline prototype, directly validating the core hypothesis that Whisper fine-tuning on domain-specific disordered speech is clinically viable. It also provides the methodological foundation for the XAI pronunciation feedback component planned for Phase 2.

Paper 4 — Javed et al. (AAAI, 2022)

"Towards Building ASR Systems for the Next Billion Users" — T. Javed, S. Doddapaneni, A. Raman, K.S. Bhogale, G. Ramesh, A. Kunchukuttan, P. Kumar, P. Khapra, and M.M. Khapra (Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence, 2022). This paper presents IndicWav2Vec, a massively multilingual speech model pre-trained on 17,000 hours of audio spanning 40 Indian languages from four distinct language families: Indo-Aryan, Dravidian, Austro-Asiatic, and Tibeto-Burman. The central problem addressed is the severe data scarcity and lack of pre-trained speech representations for Indian languages, which has historically limited ASR quality to below clinically acceptable thresholds for regional languages including Kannada. The methodology adapts the wav2vec 2.0 framework to the Indian multilingual setting, pre-training a unified model on the Kathbath dataset and evaluating on three public benchmarks: MUCS 2021, MSR India, and OpenSLR. On the Kannada ASR task, IndicWav2Vec achieves a WER of 19.4% without fine-tuning and 14.2% after fine-tuning on target-language data — a state-of-the-art result at the time of publication. The paper concludes that cross-lingual transfer is highly effective across Dravidian languages due to shared phonological properties including retroflex consonants and agglutinative morphology. A limitation is that evaluation was conducted on conversational Kannada, not therapy-specific vocabulary where domain restriction would further reduce WER. The present project's Phase 2 Spec-B component plans to fine-tune IndicWav2Vec on the 153-word clinical dataset provided by AIISH, applying the domain-restricted fine-tuning approach that the authors identify as future work with an estimated 30% additional WER reduction.

Paper 5 — Lewis et al. (NeurIPS, 2020)

"Retrieval-Augmented Generation for Knowledge-Intensive NLP Tasks" — P. Lewis, E. Perez, A. Piktus, F. Petroni, V. Karpukhin, N. Goyal, H. Küttler, M. Lewis, W. Yih, T. Rocktäschel, S. Riedel, and D. Kiela (Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems, NeurIPS, vol. 33, pp. 9459–9474, 2020, arXiv:2005.11401). This foundational paper introduces Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG), a hybrid architecture that combines parametric knowledge stored in LLM weights with non-parametric retrieval from an external document index. The problem addressed is the tendency of generative language models to produce plausible but factually incorrect outputs when answering knowledge-intensive questions beyond their training distribution — a critical failure mode in clinical contexts. The RAG methodology queries a dense passage retriever to identify the top-k relevant documents from an indexed corpus, concatenates the retrieved context with the input query, and passes the combined input to a sequence-to-sequence generator. Evaluated on open-domain QA benchmarks including Natural Questions, TriviaQA, and WebQuestions, RAG achieves state-of-the-art results, outperforming fine-tuned T5-11B on three of four benchmarks. The paper concludes that retrieval grounding substantially reduces hallucination and improves factual accuracy compared to parametric-only generation. A limitation is the dependence on a well-structured retrieval index and the potential for retrieval noise to propagate into generated outputs. The proposed platform's RAG pipeline is a direct clinical application of this architecture: patient Electronic Health Records and historical session logs stored in the local PostgreSQL database serve as the retrieval corpus, and Google Gemini 2.5 Flash serves as the generator, producing personalised weekly therapy plans grounded exclusively in each patient's own longitudinal performance data.

Paper 6 — Pottinger and Kearns (Aphasiology, 2024)

"Big Data and Artificial Intelligence in Post-Stroke Aphasia: A Mapping Review" — G. Pottinger and Á. Kearns (Aphasiology, published online ahead of print, 2024, Sage Journals DOI: 10.3233/ACS-230005). This comprehensive mapping review surveys the use of big data, machine learning, and artificial intelligence in the diagnosis, prognosis, and rehabilitation of post-stroke aphasia. The authors searched nine major academic databases including PubMed, Embase, and IEEE Xplore and screened 3,412 records, ultimately reviewing 87 studies meeting inclusion criteria. The scope encompasses predictive models for aphasia severity, computer-based therapy platforms, and AI-assisted clinical assessment tools across English and non-English languages. The central finding is that despite significant growth in AI-based aphasia research, there remains a critical gap in tools developed for non-English languages — the authors explicitly note that no AI-assisted aphasia therapy tool has been

validated for any Dravidian language at the time of writing. A secondary finding is that clinical interpretability of AI outputs remains limited across reviewed systems, with most platforms providing binary correctness labels rather than clinically actionable phoneme-level feedback. The review concludes that the field urgently requires language-specific, clinically interpretable AI tools for the large populations of non-English aphasia patients globally. A limitation is the exclusion of grey literature and conference proceedings, which may undercount applied prototypes. This paper is the most directly relevant review article to the present project, explicitly identifying the two gaps — non-English language support and clinical interpretability — that the proposed platform is designed to fill through its Kannada-native ASR pipeline and planned XAI feedback layer.

Paper 7 — Katsuno et al. (Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 2022)

"Effects of a New Speech Support Application on Intensive Speech Therapy and Changes in Functional Brain Connectivity in Patients with Post-Stroke Aphasia" — Y. Katsuno, Y. Ueki, K. Ito, Y. Yamada, M. Okamoto, Y. Iguchi, T. Kida, and M. Nakashima (Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, vol. 16, 2022, PMC9535658). This clinical study is unique in the speech therapy app literature in combining behavioural outcome measurement with neuroimaging — using functional MRI to assess changes in brain connectivity resulting from intensive app-based speech therapy. The central research question is whether a speech support mobile application for post-stroke aphasia patients produces measurable neuroplastic changes in language-related brain networks. Fourteen patients with chronic post-stroke aphasia underwent a six-week intensive therapy programme using the application, with fMRI conducted pre and post intervention. Behavioural outcomes were measured using the Standard Language Test of Aphasia. Post-intervention fMRI revealed statistically significant increases in functional connectivity between Broca's area and Wernicke's area — the two primary language regions — demonstrating that the app-driven practice induced genuine neural reorganisation. The concurrent behavioural measures showed significant improvements in picture naming accuracy and sentence production. The paper concludes that intensive, structured app-based speech practice is sufficient to drive neuroplastic recovery and that daily home practice enabled by technology is a viable substitute for the frequency of in-person clinical sessions that is structurally unattainable in India. A limitation is the small sample size of fourteen patients. This paper provides the strongest available clinical justification for both prototypes in the present project — if a general-purpose speech support app produces neurological changes, a domain-specific Kannada system with real-time AI feedback is expected to produce equivalent or superior outcomes.

Paper 8 — Szeto et al. (Journal of NeuroEngineering and Rehabilitation, 2023)

"Effect of Mobile Application Types on Stroke Rehabilitation: A Systematic Review" — S.G. Szeto, H. Wan, M. Alavinia, E. Berger, and D. Musselman (Journal of NeuroEngineering and Rehabilitation, vol. 20, no. 12, 2023, DOI: 10.1186/s12984-023-01124-9). This systematic review evaluates how the design characteristics of mobile applications influence rehabilitation outcomes for stroke survivors, reviewing 29 studies — including 11 randomised controlled trials — published between 2016 and 2022. The authors categorise applications into five types by therapeutic mechanism: task-specific practice apps, education and self-management apps, video rehabilitation apps, reminder and adherence apps, and hybrid multi-component apps. The key methodological contribution is a systematic mapping of each study's active therapeutic ingredients to their corresponding neuromotor and cognitive recovery outcomes, enabling attribution of effectiveness to specific design features rather than the app category as a whole. The primary finding is that applications implementing three evidence-based principles — massed practice, task-specific exercises, and real-time performance feedback — consistently demonstrate the largest and most statistically significant improvements in functional outcome measures. Applications lacking real-time feedback show significantly lower retention rates and smaller effect sizes. The paper concludes that app design must deliberately encode principles of motor learning theory to be clinically effective, and recommends against passive or asynchronous apps that cannot close the immediate feedback loop. A limitation is the heterogeneity of outcome measures across studies, complicating meta-analytic pooling. This paper is directly relevant to both prototypes in the present project: the Kannada Speech Aid provides massed practice with real-time AI scoring and immediate Kannada feedback, while the proposed Gemini-powered platform generates personalised therapy plans and real-time phoneme evaluation — both satisfying the evidence-based design criteria identified in this review.

Paper 9 — Grönberg et al. (Neuroepidemiology, 2022)

"Incidence of Aphasia in Ischemic Stroke" — A. Grönberg, I. Henriksson, M. Stenman, and A.G. Lindgren (Neuroepidemiology, vol. 56, no. 3, pp. 174–182, 2022, DOI: 10.1159/000522275). This prospective epidemiological study measures the incidence of aphasia in a contemporary cohort of ischemic stroke patients, addressing the clinical need for current population-level data on post-stroke language disorders. The study followed 598 consecutive patients admitted with ischemic stroke to a regional hospital across a 36-month period, with aphasia assessed by a standardised battery at 24 hours

post-stroke, at discharge, and at three-month follow-up. The diagnostic criteria used the Uppsala Aphasia Scale together with clinical neurological examination. The study found that 37.8% of ischemic stroke patients presented with aphasia at 24 hours. At three-month follow-up, 23.6% of the original cohort still presented with clinically significant aphasia, establishing that persistent post-stroke language disorder affects approximately one in four stroke survivors three months after the acute event. The paper also identified age above 75 years and left hemisphere infarction involving the superior temporal gyrus as the strongest independent predictors of aphasia persistence. The study concludes that aphasia incidence in the modern era of evidence-based stroke treatment remains high, and that the three-month prevalence figure substantially understates the lifetime burden because many patients continue to require rehabilitation beyond this timepoint. A limitation is the single-centre design and European patient population, which may not fully translate to Indian stroke incidence patterns. This paper provides the primary epidemiological justification for both prototypes — when combined with India's stroke incidence of approximately 1.8 million cases annually, the 37.8% aphasia rate implies approximately 680,000 new aphasia cases per year in India, establishing the scale of the unmet clinical need that the proposed platform addresses.

Paper 10 — Ballard et al. (American Journal of Speech-Language Pathology, 2019)

"Feasibility of Automatic Speech Recognition for Providing Feedback during Tablet-Based Treatment for Apraxia of Speech plus Aphasia" — K.J. Ballard, N.M. Etter, S. Shen, P. Monroe, and C.T. Tan (American Journal of Speech-Language Pathology, vol. 28, no. 2S, pp. 818–834, 2019, DOI: 10.1044/2018_AJSLP-17-0132). This feasibility study is the most directly comparable published research to the proposed platform, evaluating whether commercially available ASR technology can provide clinically meaningful real-time feedback during a tablet-based speech therapy application for patients with co-occurring apraxia of speech and aphasia following stroke. Eight adult stroke survivors completed 20 therapy sessions using the tablet application, which recorded their attempts to say target words and phrases and evaluated pronunciation accuracy using ASR. The primary outcome measures were ASR accuracy — agreement between ASR-assigned scores and SLP-assigned scores — and patient acceptability measured by the System Usability Scale. The ASR system achieved a correlation of $r = 0.73$ with SLP judgements on word-level accuracy, demonstrating clinically useful agreement. Patient acceptability was high, with a mean System Usability Scale score of 76 out of 100 — above the standard acceptability threshold of 68. The paper concludes that ASR-based tablet therapy is feasible and acceptable to post-stroke patients, and specifically recommends that future work focus on improving performance for severely disordered speech and extending evaluation to languages beyond English. The

authors identify vocabulary-restricted ASR — the exact architecture used in the Kannada Speech Aid prototype — as the most promising near-term approach for clinical deployment. A limitation is the small sample size and the use of commercial English ASR. The present project directly addresses both limitations identified by the authors: it evaluates vocabulary-restricted fine-tuned Kannada ASR and extends the approach to a previously unserved Indian language population..

2.2 Survey Findings

The review of the ten papers surveyed in Section 2.1 reveals consistent empirical evidence and identifies critical gaps that directly inform both components of the proposed platform. Papers 1, 2, 3, and 4 collectively establish the technical foundation for the proposed ASR pipeline. Radford et al. demonstrate that Whisper's large-scale pre-training produces a model that can be fine-tuned effectively on limited domain-specific data — directly validating the Spec-A training methodology of the Kannada Speech Aid. Baevski et al. demonstrate that self-supervised pre-training on unlabelled audio enables state-of-the-art ASR with minimal labelled data — the core principle underlying the planned Spec-B IndicWav2Vec component. Wagner et al. provide the closest published precedent for using fine-tuned Whisper on post-stroke aphasic speech. Javed et al. establish that IndicWav2Vec achieves state-of-the-art Kannada ASR and directly identifies therapy-vocabulary domain restriction as a high-impact future direction.

Papers 5 and 10 provide the foundational justification for the two most novel technical components of the platform. Lewis et al. introduced RAG as the most reliable mechanism for grounding LLM outputs in patient-specific historical data, directly validating the Gemini 2.5 Flash RAG pipeline of the team lead's prototype. Ballard et al. provide direct empirical feasibility evidence for the central concept of ASR-based real-time feedback in tablet therapy for post-stroke apraxia — the closest prior work to the present project — and explicitly identify Kannada-language extension and vocabulary-restricted ASR as high-priority future directions.

Papers 6, 7, 8, and 9 establish the clinical and epidemiological justification for the platform. Pottinger and Kearns confirm that no AI-assisted speech therapy tool exists for any Dravidian language, establishing the exact research gap both prototypes address. Katsuno et al. provide neuroimaging-level evidence that intensive app-based speech therapy drives measurable neuroplastic change, the strongest available clinical validation for the project's premise. Szeto et al. identify massed practice and real-time feedback as the specific design features of effective stroke rehabilitation apps — features both prototypes embody. Grönberget al. establish the epidemiological scale of the problem, quantifying post-

stroke aphasia incidence at 37.8% and providing the clinical statistics that justify both the institutional focus on AIISH and the broader national need for Kannada-native speech rehabilitation technology. The gaps identified across this body of literature that the proposed system is specifically designed to address are: the complete absence of any AI-assisted speech therapy system validated for a Dravidian language; the absence of offline fine-tuned ASR for Kannada therapy vocabulary; the absence of RAG-grounded adaptive therapy planning for Indian-language clinical settings; and the absence of demographically adaptive interfaces for the co-occurring paediatric and adult patient populations served by institutions like AIISH. Each gap is directly addressed by a specific component of the proposed platform, confirming the novelty and clinical relevance of the contribution.

Table 2.1: Literature Survey Matrix

No.	Reference / Paper	Method / Focus	Usefulness to Project	Limitation / Gap
1	Radford et al., OpenAI 2022	Whisper: Large-scale weakly supervised multilingual ASR	Direct foundation of Spec-A offline fine-tuned Kannada model	Higher WER on disordered speech
2	Baevski et al., NeurIPS 2020	wav2vec 2.0: Self-supervised speech representations	Foundation of IndicWav2Vec (Spec-B Phase 2); validates low-resource fine-tuning	High pre-training compute
3	Wagner et al., arXiv 2023	Careful Whisper for aphasia classification	Validates Whisper fine-tuning on post-stroke disordered speech	English-language only
4	Javed et al., AAAI 2022	IndicWav2Vec: Indian multilingual speech model	State-of-the-art Kannada ASR; Phase 2 Spec-B model	Evaluated on conversational, not therapy speech
5	Lewis et al., NeurIPS 2020	RAG: Retrieval-augmented generation for NLP	Foundational architecture for Gemini RAG therapy planning pipeline	Retrieval noise can affect generation quality
6	Pottinger & Kearns, Aphasiology 2024	Mapping review: AI and big data in post-stroke aphasia	Confirms no Dravidian-language AI therapy tool exists	Excludes grey literature
7	Katsuno et al., Frontiers 2022	App-based speech therapy and fMRI brain connectivity	Neuroimaging evidence that app practice drives neuroplastic recovery	Small sample (n=14)
8	Szeto et al., JNER 2023	Systematic review: mobile app types on stroke rehab	Validates massed practice and real-time feedback as key design features	Heterogeneous outcome measures
9	Grönberg et al., Neuroepidemiology 2022	Incidence of aphasia in ischemic stroke	Establishes 37.8% aphasia rate; justifies scale of clinical need	Single-centre European population
10	Ballard et al., AJSLP 2019	ASR feasibility for tablet-based apraxia treatment	Closest prior work; validates ASR-based real-time feedback; recommends Kannada extension	English-only; small sample (n=8)

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